

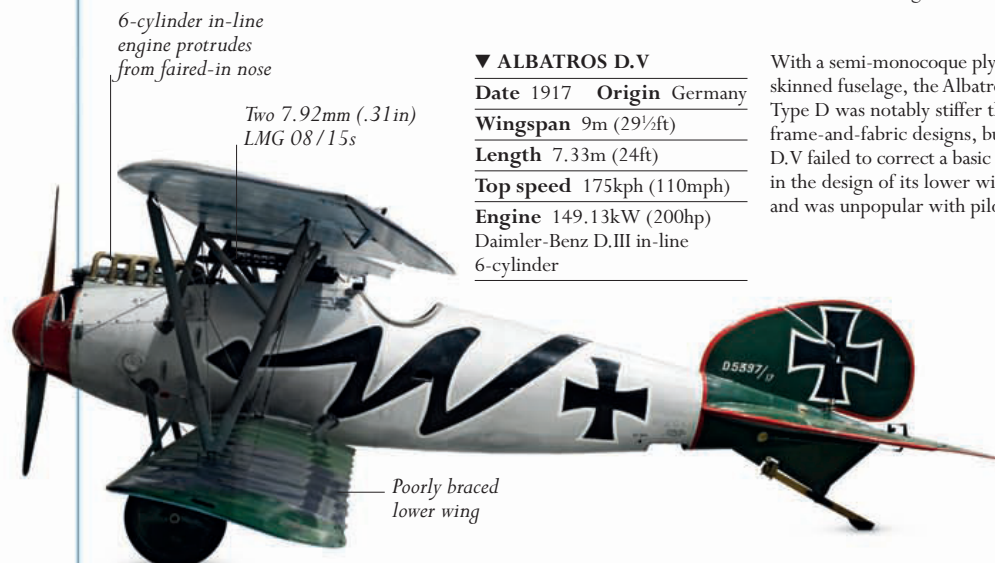
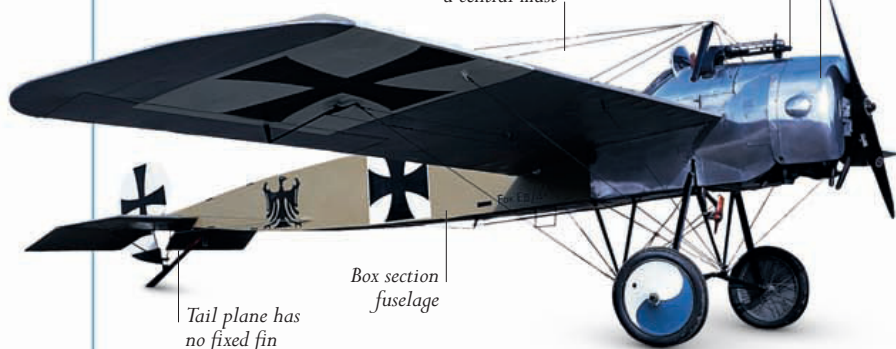
RECONNAISSANCE AND FIGHTER AIRCRAFT

Initially, military aircraft were employed to observe the battlefield, but there was soon an imperative to control the airspace over it. The first aerial “dogfights” involved pistols and rifles, and were inconclusive. Machine-guns, which could be fired in bursts while the pilot corrected his aim, were the answer. However, it was not until a method was developed of allowing such weapons to follow the pilot’s natural sightline, and fire through the propeller’s arc, that the fighter aircraft really came into its own. The first such attempts saw propeller blades fitted with strips of steel to deflect bullets, but soon after “interrupter” mechanisms were developed, which shut off the gun while the blade passed through the line of fire.

► S.E.5A

Date	1917	Origin	UK
Wingspan	8.11m (26½ft)		
Length	6.38m (21ft)		
Top speed	225kph (140mph)		
Engine	149.13kW (200hp)		
	Hispano-Suiza 8b or Wolsley W4a “Viper” in-line V-8		

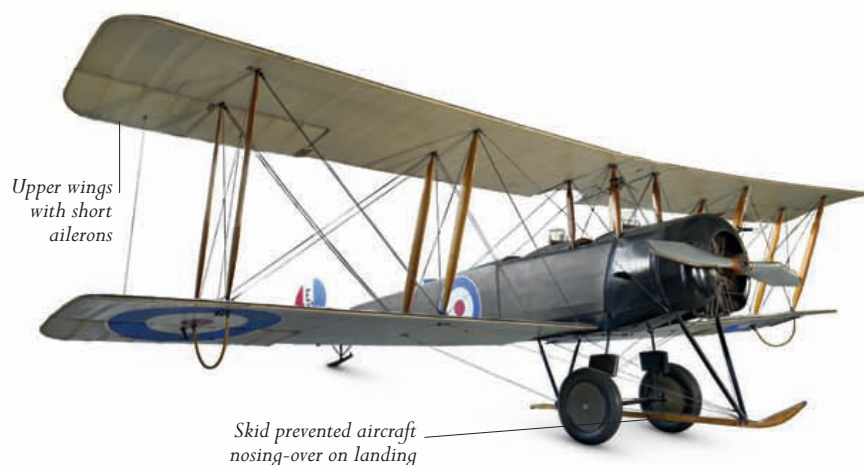
The S.E.5a was an upgraded version of what was already an extremely powerful aircraft. It was superior to the contemporary Fokker D.VII in terms of stability and speed, and had much better high-altitude performance.



▼ ALBATROS D.V

Date	1917	Origin	Germany
Wingspan	9m (29½ft)		
Length	7.33m (24ft)		
Top speed	175kph (110mph)		
Engine	149.13kW (200hp)		
	Daimler-Benz D.III in-line 6-cylinder		

With a semi-monocoque plywood-skinned fuselage, the Albatros Type D was notably stiffer than frame-and-fabric designs, but the D.V failed to correct a basic defect in the design of its lower wing, and was unpopular with pilots.



▲ AVRO 504K

Date	1917	Origin	UK
Wingspan	10.97m (36ft)		
Length	8.97m (29½ft)		
Top speed	145kph (90mph)		
Engine	82kW (110hp)		
	Le Rhône 9Ja single-bank 9-cylinder rotary		

Early versions of the Avro 504 served as reconnaissance and combat aircraft, but the two-seater 504K came into its own as a trainer. Over 10,000 were built over a period of almost 20 years.



◀ FOKKER EII

Date	1915	Origin	Germany
Wingspan	8m (26¼ft)		
Length	7.3m (24ft)		
Top speed	150kph (93mph)		
Engine	74.5kW (100hp)		
	Oberursel U.19 single-bank 9-cylinder rotary		

Dutchman Anton Fokker’s monoplane was an improved copy of the Morane-Saulnier. Its short-lived success was due solely to it being the first aircraft fitted with synchronizing interrupter gear for its gun.

